The Seasonal Almanac

by Dorothy Whitfield

Chapter 1: Spring

Spring arrives not as a single event but as a sequence of small awakenings. The soil loosens before the first shoots appear. Birdsong returns before the leaves do. The careful observer notices these precursors and prepares accordingly.

The **equinox** marks the astronomical beginning, but the *practical* start of spring varies by latitude, altitude, and local microclimate. A gardener in the lowlands may be planting weeks before one in the hills.

Early Planting

Root vegetables tolerate cool soil better than fruiting crops. Begin with radishes, carrots, and turnips. These can be sown directly as soon as the ground can be worked.

Soil Preparation

Turn the soil to a depth of eight inches. Incorporate compost at a ratio of one part compost to three parts native soil. Test pH if possible — most vegetables prefer 6.0 to 7.0.

Chapter 2: Summer

The long days of summer demand attention to watering schedules above all else. Most garden plants require approximately one inch of water per week, delivered consistently rather than in sporadic heavy doses.

Heat Management

Mulch serves double duty in summer: it retains moisture and suppresses weeds. Apply two to three inches of organic mulch around established plants, keeping it away from stems to prevent rot.

Chapter 3: Autumn

The harvest season rewards patience and planning. Crops planted in spring reach maturity, and the **second planting window** opens for cool-weather crops that will carry through early winter.

Preserving the Harvest

Canning, drying, and root-cellaring each suit different produce. Tomatoes and fruits preserve well in jars. Herbs dry readily in bundled bunches hung in a warm, dry space with good airflow.